

**Maria Silva**

38, Marlborough Road, Maidenhead, Berkshire · +447935308070 · mariafgsilva10@gmail.com ·  
linkedin.com/in/mariafgsilva10

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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Paralegal position in Field Seymour Parkes' Family team because family law is an area where I have direct client-facing experience, and the Reading location fits my current base well.

At Citizens Advice East Berkshire I advise clients across family, welfare benefits, housing and employment matters. Family cases have consistently been among the most demanding: clients often arrive in crisis, and the work requires taking a detailed factual statement, identifying the relevant legal issues quickly and translating procedural requirements into plain guidance that someone under significant stress can act on. Managing those matters from first interview through to submission, while maintaining confidential records and meeting deadlines, is the core of what I do each week.

My year at Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner gave me a strong grounding in the administrative and procedural side of legal work. In the Real Estate Disputes team I prepared electronic hearing bundles, assisted with skeleton arguments, managed court filings and maintained matter records across several active files with competing deadlines. In the International Arbitration team I coordinated documents across a complex investment arbitration as the only junior supporting the team in the weeks before a significant submission deadline, tracking outstanding actions and liaising with the client on required documents. That combination of case-file management, deadline tracking and client communication is directly transferable to supporting a busy family team.

I chose to study dispute resolution at LLM level at Queen Mary, covering procedural issues, evidence analysis and international arbitration, because I wanted to understand how legal proceedings are actually constructed and run, not just the substantive law behind them. That focus on procedure and case preparation is what I find most useful in practice, and it shapes how I approach file management and client advice at Citizens Advice.

Field Seymour Parkes has a strong reputation in the Thames Valley and the Family team's standing in the area is well known. I want to build experience in a specialist team where family work is taken seriously, and where I can develop the depth of knowledge that comes from handling a high volume of matters in a single practice area. This role is the right next step for that.

Yours sincerely,  
Maria Silva